



Health



Mental Health



Disability Rights



Chronic Fatigue Syndrome



Pain



Beyond the Diagnosis

Harish Andela Navigates his Life with Myalgic Encephalomyelitis/Chronic Fatigue Syndrome (ME/CFS) and Invisible Disabilities

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The Challenge of Invisible Disabilities

Chronic illness changes your life in ways you never expected. Invisible disabilities like mine (ME/CFS) are a challenge because there is no right way of being sick with them. When you are sick with any other condition, the normal thing to do is seek help from doctors. You fall sick, you go to a doctor, you take the pills, and you get better. Sometimes, things are worse and you will have an incurable illness. In such a case, society at least understands the incurable illness and sympathizes with the patient. Neither is true for me or hundreds of thousands of people suffering from invisible disabilities like ME/CFS, Fibromyalgia, Long COVID, etc.

The Long Road to Diagnosis

When you have one of these invisible conditions, getting a diagnosis takes years. Talking from my own experience, I visited countless doctors all over the country for four years without any success. I have done repeated blood tests and scans trying to find an answer that never came. One time I remember sitting in the waiting room of a hospital with a head-splitting migraine, waiting for the lab technician to collect my blood. I was on the verge of tears from the pain, sitting alone under the fluorescent lights that made my migraine worse. Despite the pain, I kept telling myself that the wait was worth the tears because it might lead to answers. My hopes were in vain as the tests did not reveal anything abnormal. I would ultimately get a diagnosis much

later when I came across an article about ME/CFS. Such is the experience of a majority of patients with these conditions.

More often than not, doctors are of little help in diagnosing you. You would have to go through years of dismissals and condescension from the medical practitioners before you are diagnosed.

When I got my diagnosis, I remember being so relieved. I thought the hard part of the battle was over. Now that I have a name for my condition, I can go about treating it. In retrospect, I was very naive. Since the general medical authorities and doctors poorly understand conditions like ME/CFS, there are no proven treatments for them. This means you can't go to a doctor and ask for a pill to make you better. What you are left with is a ton of experimentation to try and manage symptoms.

My own most taxing symptoms are brain fog, fatigue, anorexia, PEM (Post Exertional Malaise), temperature dysregulation, balance issues, and a few others.



Rest is just as important as work!

Navigating Treatment

How do I address these symptoms without medical guidance? I read patient forums on Facebook, Twitter, Reddit, and other websites to see what other patients are doing. I talk to other patients with these conditions and try to learn from their experiences. The treatments attempted by patients are unconventional and have no common theme, varying from mild ones like using supplements and vitamins to eccentric and risky ones like bee venom therapy, IV antibiotics, etc. In the past, I would have judged people who tried these unconventional treatments as unscientific and gullible. Now, I am one of them.

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When my friends learn about these treatments, they are sometimes concerned that I am taking too many risks. They think that I'm putting my health on the line trying these unproven treatments. When they express their fears, I assure them that I will be careful. But internally, I know that I would have to keep taking these risks. I would love to go to a doctor and get treated like everyone else but I and all the other patients with these conditions do not have this luxury.

Visiting a doctor would likely result in the familiar refrain: "All your test results are normal," a sentiment I've heard countless times.

Friendships and supportive relationships

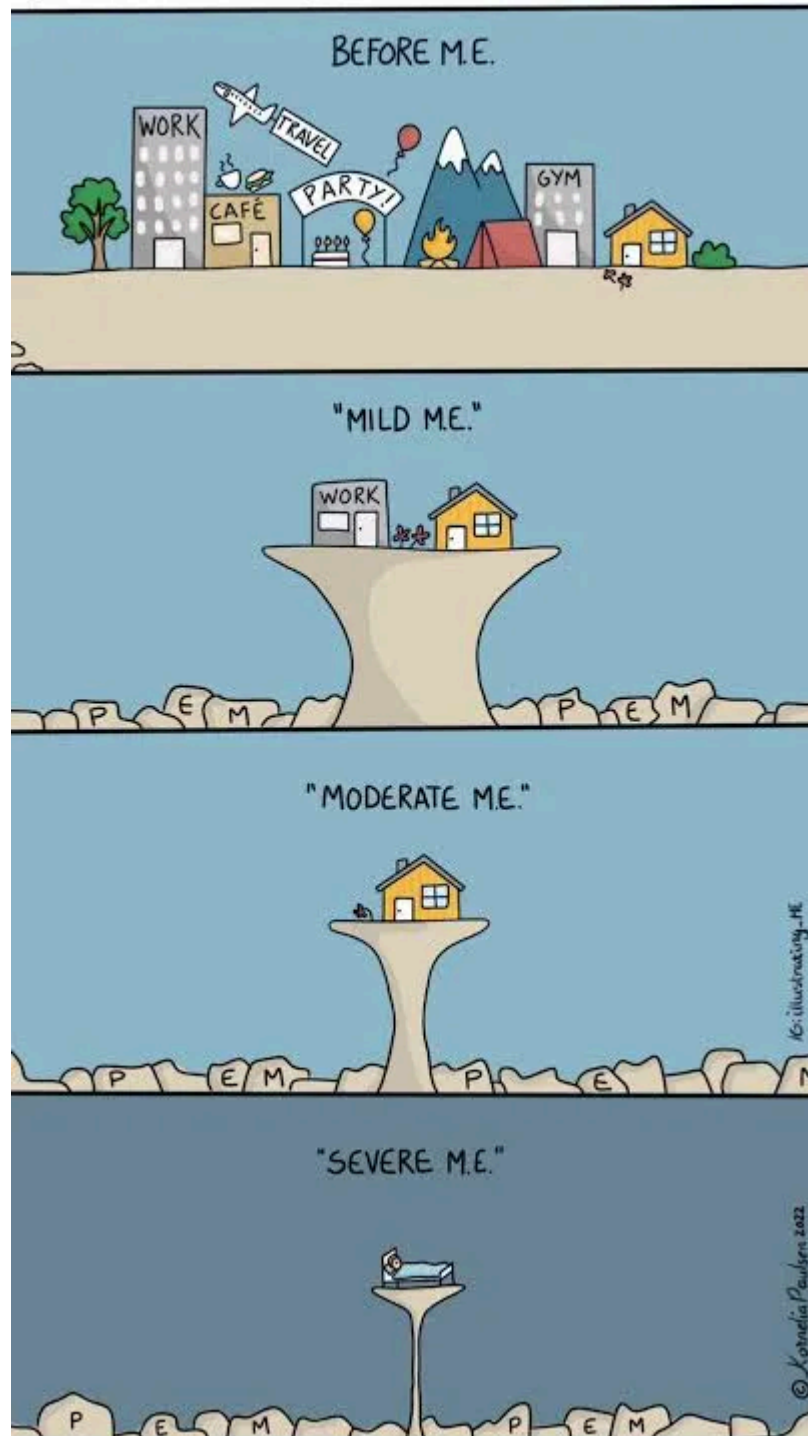
Another painful aspect of having ME/CFS is how it changes your social and family life.

Many of my friendships withered away since I got sick.

Normally when you are sick, your friends expect you to get better. That's what all the greeting cards say too — I hope you get well soon. When you don't better year after year, the dynamics of your friendships change. You go from being a friend who can hang out, go to movies, and play sports to a friend who can't. Slowly, you also have less and less in common with your friends as they move on to different colleges, jobs, etc.

M.E.

HOW IT CAN SHRINK ONE'S WORLD BITS BY BITS



I have lost so many good friends to this condition.

I have shed many tears and grieved the loss of cherished friendships. A silver lining in these losses is that I now have a few diamonds in the dirt, and a few good friends who stayed behind despite the challenges of my illness. I am eternally grateful for these people. I assume these are the kind of people who would pick up a wounded puppy from the road and bring it home. And much like the wounded puppy, I am forever indebted to their kindness.

Finding strengths

How do I cope with this incapacitating illness? It requires immense patience and overcoming the urge to succumb to despair. You have to take things one day at a time. It is not easy at all, but, with patience, you can get used to it.

I wish I could say that the struggle made me a better person, made me more resilient or wise, or whatever. This is what some others with similar illnesses say but in my case, that would not be honest. Pain and adversity shouldn't always be something to admire, something to turn into an inspiring quote or a moral lesson.

Sometimes, pain is just pain.

Sometimes, life is difficult and the best we can do is to clench our teeth and keep walking.

Harish, aged 28, currently residing in Hyderabad, and working as a freelance copywriter, has been battling illness for close to a decade.

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.

